Skill – Perception (Wisdom) · SRD 5.2.1

Perception is used to **spot, hear or detect** something: a hidden enemy, a distant sound, a secret door. It uses a **Wisdom (Perception)** check, usually via the **Search** action.

Without active effort, **passive Perception** (10 + modifiers) applies.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. **Wisdom (Perception)** check.
2. **Search** action for active searching.
3. Passive Perception: **10 + modifiers**.
4. The DC depends on the target's stealth or on difficulty.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 ties active searching to the **Search** action and keeps passive Perception.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't say how long a search takes. Fix: an action for a room, several minutes for a large area.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe a sensory detail (smell, glint, creak) before asking for the roll.

Step 1 – Announce:

The player says what they seek (trap, enemy, passage).

Step 2 – Choose the check:

Passive Perception for watchfulness; Search action for active searching.

Step 3 – Set the DC:

Against a hidden target: its Stealth check. Otherwise: DC 10 (obvious) to 20 (well hidden).

Step 4 – Roll:

1d20 + Wisdom + proficiency (if proficient).

Step 5 – Reveal:

Success reveals what's detectable; failure doesn't say nothing is there.

Example: Mira searches for a tripwire trap (DC 15). She rolls 17: she spots the wire and can disarm it.

⚠ Common questions:

Perception or Investigation?

Perception: sensing; Investigation: deducing from clues.

What does Search do?

An action to try to find something.

When is passive useful?

When characters aren't actively looking.

Can I retry?

Only if the situation changes.

Disadvantage in the dark?

Yes in Lightly Obscured areas (sight).

Is a 20 guaranteed?

No, not for ability checks.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Retrying

Retry after a failure. **Option**: only with more time.

Several searchers

The whole group searches. **Option**: one roll, the best.

Partial information

A failure gives a vague hint. **Option**: keep it.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Passive Perception

It replaces the roll for continuous watchfulness.

Hidden target

The DC is the target's Stealth check or its DC.

Search

It's an action (see the actions sheet).

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

Notices: This work includes material from the System Reference Document 5.2.1 ("SRD 5.2.1") by Wizards of the Coast LLC, available at https://www.dndbeyond.com/srd. The SRD 5.2.1 is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License, available at https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/legalcode. Unofficial sheet, 5E compatible (2024 rules), neither approved nor sponsored by Wizards of the Coast. Rules come from SRD 5.2.1; where the SRD gives no answer, explanations rely on our own interpretation. The "Table rule" parts are the author's own creations. Borders, banner, texture, titles, layout, table rules and examples: © Jaja, all rights reserved. Sources: SRD 5.2.1 (official English version); rule clarifications cross-checked with answers found on the web and reworded; numeric examples are invented; last revised: November 2026. Fonts: TeX Gyre Pagella (GUST), DejaVu Sans, Noto Color Emoji (OFL).